Service Statement

Edward A. Varvak, University of Chicago

Most of my service so far has been in the mathematics department at the University of Illinois Chicago (UIC), where I began my Ph.D. There, I have tried to give graduate students more places to learn mathematics from one another, and more people to turn to for advice.

For two semesters, from Fall 2025 through Spring 2026, I co-organized the Graduate Algebraic Geometry Seminar, a student-run seminar in which graduate students give talks on algebraic geometry. I also organized two learning seminars for graduate students: a reading group on the Weil conjectures in Fall 2025, and a seminar on Lie groups in Fall 2024. For each, I chose the topic, broke it into a dozen talks, assigned them to participants, and helped speakers prepare when they needed it.

I have also been a panelist at two events in the UIC Department of Mathematics, Statistics, and Computer Science: a geometry advising panel, where first- and second-year graduate students heard how to plan a Ph.D. in geometry, from passing preliminary exams to choosing an advisor and starting research; and a visit day panel, where I answered prospective students' questions about the program and graduate life. More informally, I have been a mentor to younger graduate students as they navigate graduate school.

Much of my teaching has been in the same community. I spent five semesters as a teaching assistant at UIC, a Hispanic-Serving Institution where many students are the first in their families to attend college. Outside the university, I judged QED, Chicago's Youth Math Symposium, run by the Math Circles of Chicago, at which students in grades 5–12 present original projects in mathematics and computer science.

At Harvard, I plan to organize a learning seminar on Lagrangian fibrations and Hitchin systems, open to graduate students and postdocs across the Boston area, and to post its notes publicly so that students without a local expert can follow along. I would also like to continue outreach by volunteering with local math circles and competitions such as HMMT.